

Foreword

The Civil War exploded in 1861 fueled by tensions over the institution of slavery that had been smoldering since before the nation's founding. In 1820, Thomas Jefferson, vexed by the expansion of slavery and the appeasement of enslavers who desired Missouri to be admitted to the United States as a state allowing human trafficking, referred to the question of slavery by writing “. . . as it is, we have the wolf by the ear, and we can neither hold him, nor safely let him go.” When that wolf broke free, the nation was torn apart in a four-year conflict that brought unprecedented death, disease, physical and psychological trauma, personal loss, and crippling grief to every corner of the nation.

When the battles depicted in the artwork and photographs in this book ended, when the rifles and cannon fell silent and found their way to museums, when the uniforms of American soldiers and insurgents were taken off for the last time, the conflict still raged on as people assessed what it all had meant and how the Civil War should be remembered.

History and memory are related but not the same. At the Smithsonian Institution, we study the history of the Civil War through the objects, documents, and artwork that make up this history. The process of reconstructing history is informed by evidence, such as the inkstand Abraham Lincoln used to write the Emancipation Proclamation or the tall hat he wore when he was murdered by a racist terrorist who was appalled that he would free the enslaved and endeavor to extend them citizenship and voting rights. In